EVIDENT AI INDEX BANKS/LATAM

The global standard benchmark of AI maturity

KEY FINDINGS REPORT



Disclaimer

Evident AI Index | Banks – LATAM: Key Findings Report, July 2026, is published by Evident Insights.

The information in this report has been obtained from sources we believe to be reliable and accurate. However, it has not been independently verified. We make no representation or warranty, express or implied, as to the accuracy or completeness of this report. We undertake no obligation to publicly revise or update this report and shall in no event be liable for any loss or damage arising in connection with the use of the information in this report.

© Evident Insights Ltd 2026

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted, in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, or otherwise for commercial gain. You may use content from the report for non-commercial use, provided that you attribute the content to "Evident AI Index | Banks - LATAM: Key Findings Report", June 2026.

EVIDENT AI INDEX BANKS/LATAM

Contents

About Evident 1

Executive Summary 2

Methodology 5

Ranking 6

Chapter 1 | Defining AI Leadership in LATAM 7

Chapter 2 | Performance Profiles of Regional Leaders 9

Chapter 3 | Trends to Watch 15

- 3.1 Talent: LATAM produces globally competitive talent, but struggles to protect it 15
- 3.2 Innovation: Expanding hyperscaler infrastructure improves access to frontier AI, pushing LATAM banks to favor "buy" vs. "build" 18
- 3.3 Leadership: Realized ROI has not laddered up to the enterprise-level (yet...) 20
- 3.4 Transparency: AI governance policy is lagging pace of AI implementation 23

About Evident

Evident is the leading intelligence and benchmarking platform for AI in financial services. We benchmark deployment across the sector, spotlight emerging trends, and equip leaders with the insights they need to accelerate AI transformation.

Businesses worldwide are ratcheting up AI investment. Those that race ahead will outcompete their rivals on growth, productivity, and financial performance. Those that fall behind risk irrelevance in a rapidly changing marketplace. And yet, despite the high stakes, visibility into how companies are approaching AI transformation remains limited.

We believe transparency is critical to realizing the full potential of AI for commercial gain. By showcasing best practice, we help companies transform faster and more safely, while maximizing commercial, economic, and societal opportunities.

The Evident AI Index is the global standard benchmark of AI maturity for financial services. It is the most comprehensive and trusted benchmark of its kind, covering over 100 financial institutions, including banks, insurers, payment networks and processors, and coming soon, asset managers.

At the heart of the Evident AI Index is independence. Its methodology relies exclusively on publicly available data. This "outside-in" approach enables us to build a more complete and comparable assessment of corporate AI maturity than survey-based approaches offer.

Financial institutions work with us to enhance competitive intelligence, identify best practices, and define KPIs specific to AI transformation – and ultimately, inform strategic decision-making. With Evident, organizations can access:

1. AI Benchmarking Services
We offer public and private AI benchmarking services to provide AI leaders with a clear, data-driven picture of their organization's AI maturity.

Public Benchmarking
Assess how your AI maturity compares with the financial institutions featured in the Evident AI Index and identify opportunities to accelerate AI capabilities.

Private Benchmarking
Benchmark your AI use cases, spend and returns against major financial institutions to determine where your AI deployment stands and where to focus investment next.

2. Intelligence
Research reports and data trackers covering the latest sector-wide trends. Our research provides members with timely, in-depth analysis of AI adoption, investment and innovation across financial services.

3. Community
Exclusive events and roundtables for senior AI leaders to connect with peers and share insights, including our flagship annual gathering – the Evident AI Symposium – taking place in October 2026 in New York City.

To learn more about how your organization can work with Evident, get in touch with our team

Alexandra Mousavizadeh
Co-CEO & Co-Founder
Alexandra.Mousavizadeh@
EvidentInsights.com

Annabel Ayles
Co-CEO & Co-Founder
Annabel.Ayles@
EvidentInsights.com

AI: THE LATEST CHALLENGE FOR REGIONAL LATAM BANKS

Banking across Latin America has historically been defined by highly concentrated markets. In Brazil, Mexico, Chile, Colombia, or Peru, a small number of incumbent institutions have benefited from deep local knowledge, and the scale to weather successive economic and political cycles, thereby creating formidable barriers to entry.

Most of those incumbents are local institutions, but since the late 90s, global banks have sought to establish a stronger footprint in the region, attracted by high interest rates and long-term growth prospects following major economic reforms. Santander, BBVA, Citigroup, HSBC, and more recently Scotiabank, for example, invested heavily through acquisitions and organic expansion.

Their presence accelerated the modernization of banking in LATAM, from the early days of internet banking to today's digital-first environment. It compelled local players to substantially enhance their technology and analytics capabilities, both to optimize internal operations and to provide customers with digital experiences on par with those of the world's leading banks.

The more technology savvy LATAM banks have mostly managed to defend their position and forced some of these globals to retrench. However, the adoption of artificial intelligence opens up a new transformative period in which foreign banks may once again challenge the status quo.

This is particularly true for the most successful global players in the region, Santander and BBVA, who have doubled down on their locally tailored operating models and established major AI hubs in Brazil and Mexico to accelerate AI development and implementation. In doing so, they are intensifying competition for already scarce AI talent - data scientists, engineers and developers - making it more difficult for local banks to scale their own AI efforts.

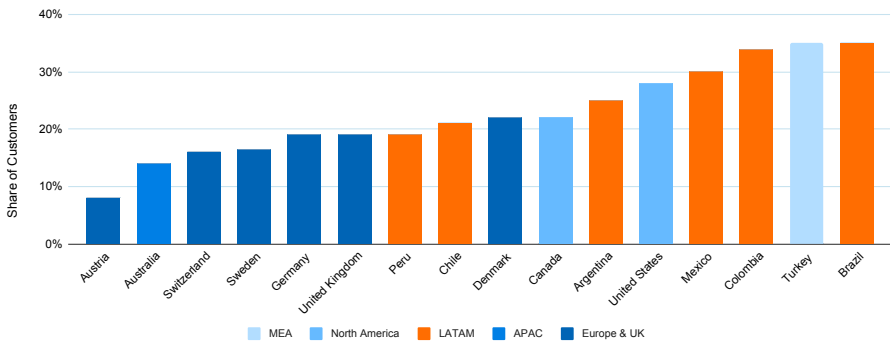
But global banks are not the only threat that AI has brought to regional LATAM banks.

A BRAVE NU WORLD

While financial inclusion has significantly improved in LATAM, the region still has one of the world's largest underbanked populations. Over the past decade, this unmet demand has fueled a second wave of (homegrown) competition – this time led by digital-native neobanks and fintechs deploying AI-enabled operations.

A recent study found that customers in Latin America were among the most likely to identify a neobank as their "primary" financial institution.

SHARE OF CUSTOMERS IDENTIFYING A NEOBANK AS PRIMARY ACCOUNT, BY COUNTRY



Source: Simon-Kucher, Global Neobanking Study, March 2026.

This shift has been facilitated not only by the combination of digital infrastructure initiatives led by central banks – including Pix in Brazil, CoDi / DiMo in Mexico, and the CBDC pilot in Peru - but also accelerated by the rise of AI, which has allowed neobanks and fintechs to better serve an increasingly digital-native customer base through conversational banking, real-time fraud detection and innovative lending solutions.

Nowhere has this phenomenon been more pronounced than in Brazil, where in little over a decade, **Nubank** has risen from a mobile-first financial services start-up to a top-15 regional bank by assets with over 100 million users and US expansion ambitions.

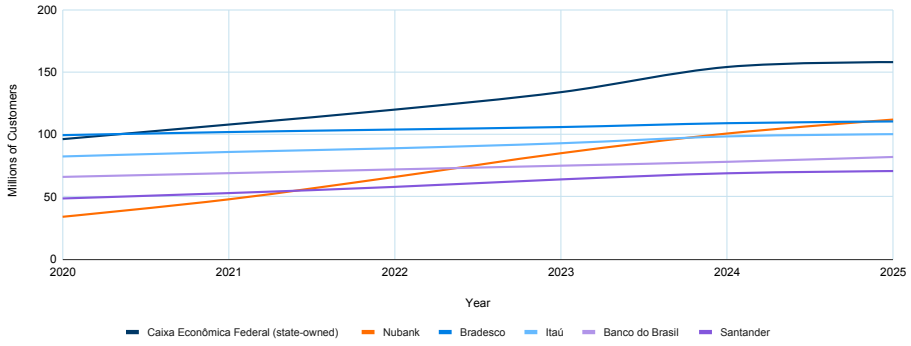
Many analysts have compared Nubank's rise to Capital One's growth story. Both apply deep data, technology and AI-driven strategies to underwrite risk and reach historically underserved customer segments. In the case of Nubank, it has leveraged novel AI-driven approaches to support real-time credit underwriting, broadening access to lending while maintaining risk levels at reasonable levels (for now).

Other fintech players outside of Brazil – Mercado Pago, Ualá, Nequi, and Albo - have adopted similar "land-and-expand" strategies, using e-commerce, prepaid cards, and mobile payments as their initial point of entry – while supercharging their propositions with AI to enable increasingly personalized offers and deeper customer engagement.

For incumbents, this has raised pressure to use their broader product sets and established customer relationships more effectively: connecting data across the bank, embedding AI into key customer journeys, and demonstrating that AI investment can translate into greater engagement, cross-selling, and customer value.

So far, the impact seems positive for everyone, as exemplified by the fact that the number of banking customers across all of the largest Brazilian banks has increased steadily since 2020 (see exhibit below).

NUMBER OF BANKING CUSTOMERS IN BRAZIL, BY INSTITUTION

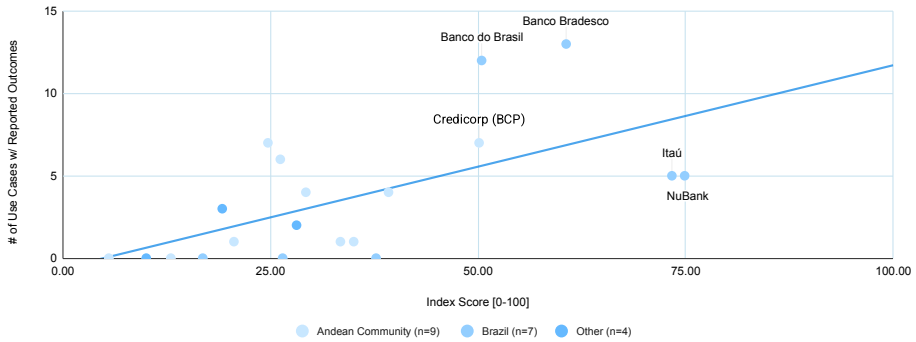


Source: Latinometrics / Banco Central do Brasil, June 2026.

I

NDEX LEADERS DRIVE ALMOST HALF OF AI USE CASES WITH OUTCOMES
Mimicking the dynamics in other regions, data from the inaugural Evident AI Index for Banks - LATAM shows how companies with higher AI maturity (as reflected in the ranking) produce more numerous (and more diverse) use cases with outcomes attached to them.

ASSESSMENT OF AI MATURITY VS. USE CASES W/ REPORTED OUTCOMES



July 2026, n=71 AI use cases

However, unlike other regions, the top-4 banks are concentrated in one single country, Brazil. **Nubank**, **Itaú Unibanco**, **Bradesco** and **Banco do Brasil** not only top the Index, but also produce almost 50% of the AI use cases with reported outcomes.

These institutions are using AI not simply to automate processes – but to redesign how banking services are delivered, priced, and personalized.

→ Nubank (#1) and Itaú Unibanco (#2), the two banks pulling ahead of the pack, while overlapping in many areas of AI implementation, have also pursued distinct use cases. Nubank has leaned more into AI for customer-facing decisions - using real-time underwriting, personalization, and agentic workflows to accelerate growth - while Itaú has embedded AI across the enterprise, from software engineering and risk modeling to legal and operational processes, generating substantial productivity gains at scale.

→ Meanwhile fast-following incumbents, Bradesco (#3) and Banco do Brasil (#4), have produced a high volume of use cases across diverse application areas. Bradesco, for example, has embedded AI into financial risk management, as well as customer engagement and software engineering. While Banco do Brasil has deployed AI across CRM, advisory, compliance, and operational processes to improve productivity, governance, and commercial effectiveness

Outside of Brazil, **Credicorp** (#5) illustrates a "do more with less" model of AI adoption, where disciplined execution and a buy-first approach helps them over-index on impactful use cases (with particular efficiency uplift reported in customer engagement applications that have automated customer query or claims processing).

Conversely, 6 of the 20 banks fail to publish any AI use cases with reported outcomes. This underscores a growing gap between leaders and laggards – based not on which banks are actively investing in AI, but between banks that can operationalize AI (at scale) and those still experimenting.

This could be a redefining moment for LATAM banks, as AI leaders are not only improving their bottom line already, but are also starting to re-draw the longstanding competitive boundaries across the region.

INDEX STRUCTURE & WEIGHT SCHEME
JULY 2026

45
% OF INDEX WEIGHT

Talent | Measures the number and density of AI & Data employees working at each bank; as well as the visible initiatives underway to hire, retain, and develop leading AI talent.

→ **Talent Capability**: The volume and density of employees working across the AI and data lifecycle. This includes analysis of 200+ job titles working across five foundational capability areas: AI Development, Data Engineering, AI Software Implementation, AI Product Management, and AI Model Risk.
→ **Talent Development:** The breadth of initiatives banks are deploying to attract, retain, and develop leading AI talent, as well as upskill the rest of the organization.

25
% OF INDEX WEIGHT

Innovation | Measures a bank's long-term investment in AI innovation, extending to AI-focused research and patents; AI-focused investments and acquisitions; as well as engagement with the open source ecosystem.

→ **Research & Patents**: The volume and caliber of the bank's AI research output and talent; participation at leading academic conferences; partnerships with academic institutions, as well as investment in and relevance of AI-focused patents.
→ **Ventures & Partnerships**: The number of investments and acquisitions of AI and Data/Tech-focused companies; assessment of external AI-related partnerships and participation in national/regional AI efforts.
→ **Open Source**: The bank's overall engagement with the open source ecosystem, including direct contributions to leading code repositories and participation in open source projects and workings.

20
% OF INDEX WEIGHT

Leadership | Measures the AI focus of the bank's leadership, expressed through the company's overarching AI narrative, composition of the executive leadership team, and external communications from select C-level executives.

→ **AI Narrative**: The bank's group-level AI narrative across direct channels (press releases, LinkedIn, investor relations materials). Includes an assessment of the bank's "coverage" across media channels (scale), as well as the "content" (substance). Our current inquiry increasingly focuses on how banks report on AI use cases and estimated business impact (ROI).
→ **Executive Positioning**: The composition of the bank's executive leadership team, and strategic focus on AI found across external communication channels.

10
% OF INDEX WEIGHT

Transparency | Measures the extent to which banks are focusing on Responsible AI (RAI), as evidenced by the publication of internal processes, establishment of key partnerships, hiring of dedicated RAI talent, and promotion of RAI principles.

→ **RAI Talent**: The presence and scale of internal RAI talent, as well as AI specialists posted across the front lines of defense (including Audit, Legal, and Compliance).
→ **RAI Innovation**: Evidence and assessment of established RAI partnerships, creation of AI governance committees, and/or adaptation of risk management frameworks; tangible outputs in the form of RAI research output, case studies, and use cases.
→ **RAI Leadership:** The extent to which banks are publicly communicating a wide range of RAI activities, such as through the publication and operationalization of guiding AI principles.

EVIDENT AI INDEX BANKS/LATAM

Evident AI Index Rankings
July 2026

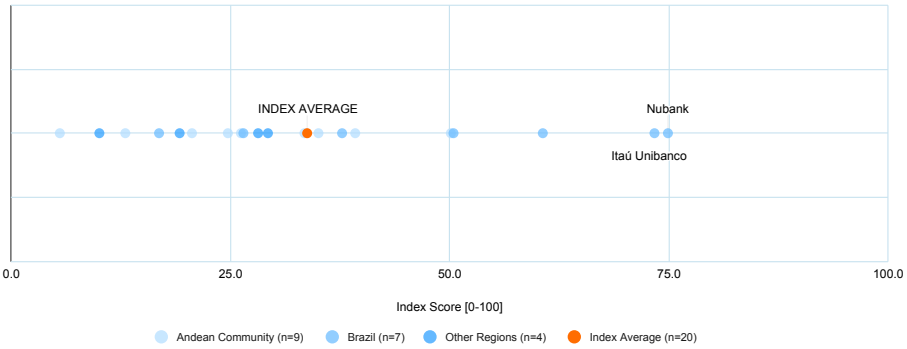
COMPANY	RANK	TALENT Capability & development	INNOVATION Research, patents, ventures, ecosystem	LEADERSHIP in public communications and strategy	TRANSPARENCY of responsible AI activities
Nubank	1	1	1	1	3
Itaú Unibanco	2	2	3	2	1
Banco Bradesco	3	3	2	2	4
Banco do Brasil	4	9	4	4	2
Credicorp (BCP)	5	4	5	7	5
Bancolombia	6	7	7	12	6
BTG Pactual	7	6	6	15	12
Intercorp (Interbank)	8	5	12	14	7
Banco Bci	9	8	11	11	8
Banorte	10	16	9	8	9
Grupo Financiero Galicia	11	10	14	10	13
Caixa Econômica Federal	12	18	8	9	11
Banco Davivienda	13	13	17	6	10
Banco de Bogotá	14	11	15	5	19
Banco de Chile	15	17	10	13	15
BAC	16	14	16	17	14
Banco Safra	17	15	13	18	16
Banco Pichincha	18	12	19	19	20
Banco Nación	19	20	18	16	17
Banco del Estado de Chile	20	19	20	20	18

RETURN TO TOP ↑

BRAZIL'S LEADING BANKS DOMINATE THE STANDINGS

Across the 20 banks assessed within Latin America, two banks stand apart in Evident's first regional benchmark of AI maturity: **Nubank** and **Itaú Unibanco**. These established leaders benefit from a rare combination of scale, digital infrastructure, and technical talent that no other regional peers can match head-to-head.

DISTRIBUTION OF OVERALL SCORES IN EVIDENT AI INDEX



July 2026, n=20 LATAM Banks

WHAT SETS THEM APART?

A shared trait between these two leaders is they do not simply invest more in AI. Instead, they operate within an ecosystem where AI grants a structural advantage over most regional peers. Let's unpack:

First, Brazil's leading banks cater to some of the largest customer bases in the Western Hemisphere – each serving 70M+ customers. At this scale, small improvements in fraud detection, customer service, collections, underwriting, or software development produce outsized economic returns. As a result, these institutions were among the first to accelerate from pilot projects to enterprise deployment. While many regional peers are still proving out AI's value, Brazilian leaders are already optimizing how to operationalize AI across millions of daily transactions.

Second, Brazil's banking sector sits on top of one of the world's most advanced financial infrastructure stacks, including:

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION
Drex (2023)	Developed by the Central Bank of Brazil, Drex is Brazil's tokenized financial infrastructure and wholesale CBDC platform designed to support programmable payments, tokenized assets, and smart-contract-based financial services.
Open Finance (2021)	Open Finance allows consumers to securely share banking, payments, insurance, and investment data across institutions through standardized APIs.
Pix (2020)	Pix is a government-backed instant payments network launched by the Central Bank of Brazil that enables real-time, low-cost transfers between consumers, businesses, and financial institutions 24/7.
Digital Identity Initiative (2019)	Brazil's digital identity ecosystem, anchored by the federal government's Gov.br platform, provides citizens with a unified digital identity for accessing financial and public services online.

Standardization of this ecosystem (championed by the Banco Central do Brasil and recently caught in geopolitical tensions with the USA) unlocks vast amounts of structured, real-time financial data. In turn, this affords AI systems richer behavioral signals, faster feedback loops, better fraud models, improved credit risk assessments, and more sophisticated personalization. Especially compared to neighboring LATAM markets where digital adoption remains fragmented, Brazilian banks operate in an environment where customers are generating uniform signals that feed and accelerate machine learning systems.

Third, while each of the leader's business models differs, both Itaú and Nubank demonstrate heavy investment in technical talent, internal platforms, and partnerships with universities and start-ups based in São Paulo – ground zero for LATAM's explosion of fintech and AI companies.

This is consistent with Evident's benchmarking data, which shows leading LATAM banks significantly outperform their regional counterparts across both Talent and Innovation pillars – key proxies for a bank's ability to develop, deploy, and scale AI platforms and applications.

GLOBAL VS. REGIONAL PROFILE OF KEY METRICS, ORGANIZED BY PILLAR

Pillar	Metric	Global Banking Average Oct 2025 n=50	LATAM Banking Leaders July 2026 (Top-2)	LATAM Banking Average July 2026 (n=20)
TALENT	Average Employee Base	78,686	75,500	32,825
	Average Volume of AI Talent	1,763	1,818	507
	Average Density of AI Talent	2.2%	3.8%	1.7%
	Average Volume of AI Development Staff	715	838	229
	Average Density of AI Development Staff	0.9%	2.0%	0.7%
	% Offering AI Training Programs	78%	100%	80%
INNOVATION	% Publishing AI Research	84%	100%	35%
	% Engaging in Patent Activity	54%	50%	20%
	% Engaging in Venture Investments	96%	100%	40%
LEADERSHIP	% Mentioning AI as Strategic Objective	74%	100%	90%
	Average # of AI Use Cases	8	5	4
	% Reporting Enterprise AI:ROI	30%	0%	0%
TRANSPARENCY	% Offering RAI Training	50%	100%	50%
	% w/ AI Governance Committee	48%	100%	45%
	% Publishing RAI Principles	48%	50%	50%

In summary, leading Brazilian banks combine the scale of banking institutions in North America and Europe, the digital infrastructure of leading fintech players, and the talent density found within mature technology ecosystems.

This combination creates a virtuous cycle: large customer bases generate data, modern public infrastructure makes that data usable, and strong engineering organizations convert it into AI-powered products and operational efficiencies.

Most Latin American banks possess one or two of those advantages, whereas Brazil's leaders tend to execute across all three simultaneously.

Two additional Brazilian banks, **Banco Bradesco** and **Banco do Brasil**, populate the sizable gap between the established leaders (Nubank and Itaú Unibanco) and the wider set of regional peers. While all four of these banks hail from the same country, each exhibits unique strategies, capabilities, and business models – producing distinct areas of strength, established best practices, and supporting use cases explored below.

2.1 NUBANK

Nubank's AI strategy is built around three core assets: a vast repository of customer transaction data, proprietary AI models, and one of the strongest AI talent bases in the region. These assets have driven a remarkable growth story not only in Brazil, but regional expansion to Mexico and Colombia, with the United States to follow in 2027 (based on conditional approval received in January 2026).

Nubank secures the top spot across three of the Index's four pillars of assessment. Historically, Evident has only observed this consistency in performance with one other financial institution: JPMorganChase. It's worth noting that Nubank is markedly different in scale, business model, and geographic footprint from other global banking leaders. In fact, Nubank only announced its intentions to obtain a full banking license last December – previously operating under a mix of payment, credit, and brokerage licenses.

Nubank's market-defining success emerged from a relentless focus on the customer experience for a digitally-native, but historically underserved, banking population. AI has long played a role in that strategy: enabling personalized products, streamlined customer onboarding, and expanded access to credit through advanced risk modeling.

This strategy involves a delicate balancing act between leveraging innovative underwriting techniques, but also maintaining a higher risk appetite than most financial institutions in the region (especially with regards to regional expansion beyond Brazil). This high-risk, high-reward approach is arguably justified by Nubank's strong predictive models, informed by channeling a decade's worth of historical data on customer interactions into proprietary AI capabilities.

This strength is further underpinned by a highly concentrated AI workforce, with AI staff representing more than 5% of total employees (3x the Index average). Widely regarded as one of the most desirable destinations for engineering talent in Brazil, Nubank has successfully attracted leading domestic technical talent while also expanding its frontier AI capabilities through strategic acquisitions such as Hyperplane in 2024. This deal allowed Nubank to access expertise in training bespoke financial foundation models on a decade of proprietary customer data, and develop their own state of the art models such as nuFormer, which delivers underwriting performance improvements approximately three times greater than traditional model upgrades.

The impact of embedding AI into core banking operations is increasingly visible across the organization. Beyond nuFormer, Nubank has implemented real-time AI underwriting that prices and approves personal loans in under one second, agentic workflows supporting collections and card delivery that have generated a 50% uplift in customer engagement, and a multimodal money-transfer system that enables customers to initiate transactions through voice, image and chat interfaces. The latter has reduced transfer times from roughly 70 seconds to under 30 seconds while maintaining customer satisfaction above 90%.

Nubank's approach also reflects a sophisticated understanding of where to build proprietary capabilities and where to leverage external innovation. While the bank has invested heavily in developing its own models and AI infrastructure, it has simultaneously partnered with the likes of OpenAI to accelerate the deployment of frontier AI capabilities across customer service, operations and internal productivity – showcasing an operating model that places it amongst the world's leading AI adopters and sets the pace for others in the region to follow.

BANK PROFILE: NUBANK

OVERALL RANK

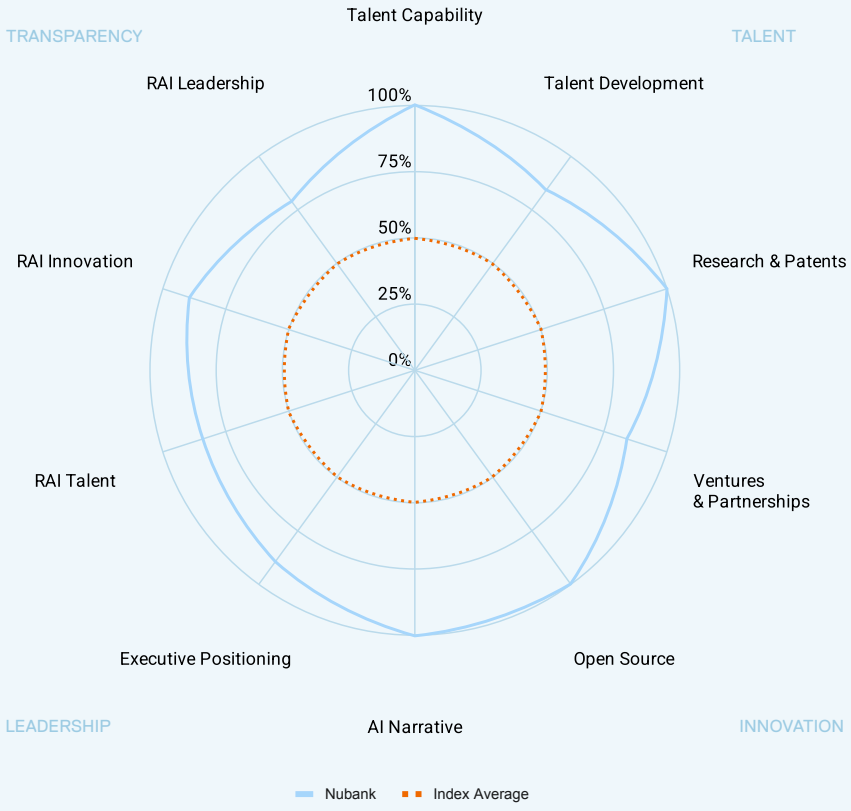
1

REGION

PILLAR RANK

TRANSPARENCY	TALENT
3	1
LEADERSHIP	**INNOVATION**
1	1

Index Performance Profile: Nubank
Percentile Rank of Index Score, by Subpillar



2.2 ITAÚ UNIBANCO

Reinforcing Brazil's dominance in the regional rankings, Itaú Unibanco's second-place finish offers a striking counterpoint to AI-native leader Nubank. As the largest bank in the Index by headcount (~93k employees) and assets (~$580B USD), Itaú has pursued AI transformation from a vastly different starting point. Formed through the 2008 merger of Banco Itaú and Unibanco, scaling AI across this Latin American banking giant has meant a complete overhaul of complex legacy systems, processes and organizational structures.

Rather than relying on a small number of flagship AI initiatives, Itaú's strategy has been built around establishing the institutional foundations required to scale AI across the enterprise. This is reflected in the sheer volume of its AI workforce. While Nubank demonstrates the most concentrated density of AI talent relative to overall company headcount, Itaú leads the Index (by a considerable margin) in terms of absolute volume of AI talent that Evident tracks by role, function, and overarching capability area.

That talent base has enabled Itaú to pursue some of the most ambitious productivity initiatives in the region. The bank's 2025 Annual Report describes "one of the world's largest coordinated adoptions of autonomous AI agents by a financial institution," with AI agents embedded throughout the software development lifecycle as a source of institutional knowledge and engineering support. This program has delivered productivity gains of up to 30%, with approximately 75% of engineering teams adopting the solution.

Beyond software engineering, Itaú has focused on augmenting highly skilled professional work at scale. Generative AI agents have increased the productivity of model validation and risk development teams by as much as sevenfold, while AI-enabled legal systems now perform more than 15,000 legal analyses per month and have generated an estimated $75M BRL ($14M USD) in contingency savings.

Crucially, Itaú's ability to scale these use cases is underpinned by a highly centralized platform and governance model. Speaking at the bank's 2025 Investor Day, CEO Milton Maluhy Filho noted that roughly 70% of investment in scalable AI platforms has been directed toward control mechanisms, including dedicated "Red Teams" tasked with stress-testing models, identifying vulnerabilities and strengthening safeguards before deployment.

This emphasis on governance is reflected in Itaú's first-place ranking in the Transparency pillar. Through its work on "Algorithmic Ethics," the bank has operationalized responsible AI principles into formal processes for monitoring, evaluating and mitigating risks associated with increasingly autonomous AI systems.

BANK PROFILE: ITAÚ UNIBANCO

OVERALL RANK

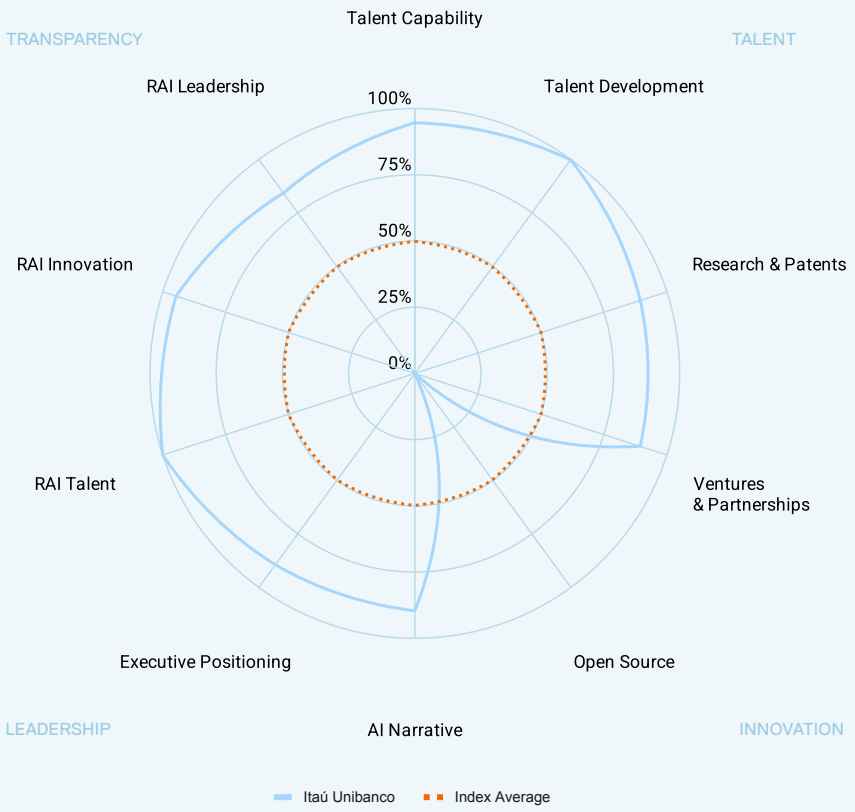
2

REGION

PILLAR RANK

TRANSPARENCY	TALENT
1	2
LEADERSHIP	**INNOVATION**
2	3

Index Performance Profile: Itaú Unibanco
Percentile Rank of Index Score, by Subpillar



2.3 BANCO BRADESCO

Bradesco has invested heavily in building the internal capabilities required to scale AI across the organization. Historically reliant on outsourced technology talent, the bank has sought to internalize critical AI and engineering expertise under CEO Marcelo Noronha's transformation agenda, which we see reflected in the bank registering the second highest number of employees working in AI talent roles out of any LATAM bank covered in the Index.

This talent strategy has been complemented by major technology partnerships, most notably with Microsoft Azure, which underpins Bradesco's multi-agent generative AI platform (BRIDGE) and virtual assistant (BIA). Acting as a common enterprise layer for AI deployment, Bridge now supports more than 500 initiatives across customer and employee use cases. BIA for Customers delivers personalized interactions to approximately 74 million customers and achieves resolution rates above 80%, while BIA Corporate provides employees with AI-powered assistance for internal queries, similarly resolving the majority of requests without human intervention. Whilst they have also embedded agentic capabilities into WhatsApp for retail customers to automate payments using voice or image recognition.

A defining feature of Bradesco's AI transformation has also been its willingness to combine internal development with targeted venture activity – a significant driver of its #3 ranking in Innovation. A notable example was the 2023 acquisition of AI specialist Kunumi, a university spin-off focused on machine learning and advanced analytics.

This capability has been deployed across a diverse portfolio of use cases, with a particular emphasis on Financial Risk Management application areas. Bradesco has embedded machine learning into credit approval, income estimation and collections processes, generating measurable improvements in both efficiency and decision quality. The business impact has been significant: André Duarte Oliveira, Bradesco's Head of Credit, has estimated that AI-enabled credit initiatives have generated more than $1B BRL ($193M USD) in value since the bank's transformation program began in 2023.

BANK PROFILE: BANCO BRADESCO

OVERALL RANK

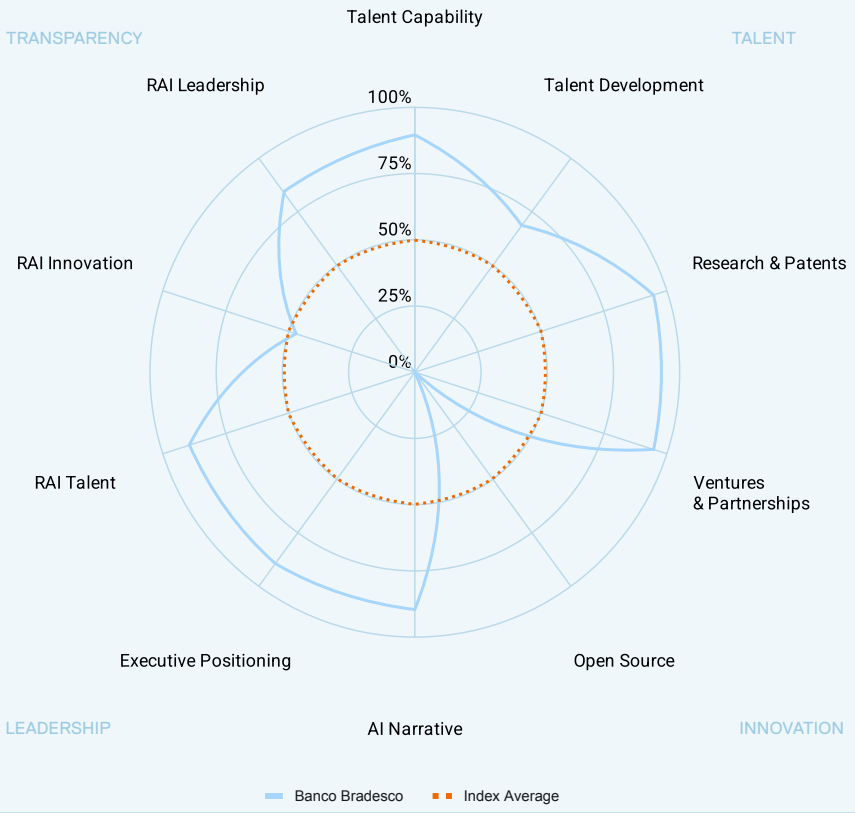
3

REGION

PILLAR RANK

TRANSPARENCY	TALENT
4	3
LEADERSHIP	**INNOVATION**
2	2

Index Performance Profile: Banco Bradesco
Percentile Rank of Index Score, by Subpillar



2.4 BANCO DO BRASIL

Rounding out the top-4, Banco do Brasil has made scale a defining feature of its AI strategy. By Q1 2026, the bank reported more than 2,000 AI solutions in production, including over 1,200 models spanning traditional machine learning, generative AI and agentic AI. These deployments extend across customer service, credit, risk management and operational efficiency, making Banco do Brasil one of the most extensive AI adopters in the region.

The bank is accruing benefits across this diverse set of use cases, with one example including an investment recommendation tool that since rolling out to 1.4 million customers has been "generating R$6 million in revenues and nearly R$700,000 in contribution margin in the first months of use" ($1.2M and $136k USD, respectively).

The breadth of this adoption is increasingly translating into measurable business impact. CEO Tarciana Medeiros noted that AI-enabled processes were already generating more than 41,000 hours of efficiency gains per month during 2025.

What distinguishes Banco do Brasil, however, is not only the scale of its AI deployment but the sophistication of the governance framework supporting it. Ranked second in the Index's Transparency pillar, the bank is among a small group of institutions that explicitly describe how model risk management has evolved to accommodate the emergence of generative and agentic AI overseen by its Technical Model Risk Forum (FRM).

The significance of this shift is reflected in the bank's risk taxonomy. In its 2025 reporting, Banco do Brasil acknowledged that the strategic importance of generative and agentic AI had expanded model risk beyond the boundaries of traditional statistical and machine-learning models. As a result, Model Risk was elevated to a standalone Level-1 risk category, no longer treated as a subcomponent of Operational Risk. This represents one of the clearest examples in the Index of a bank adapting its risk governance architecture to reflect the growing autonomy, complexity and strategic importance of modern AI systems.

BANK PROFILE: BANCO DO BRASIL

OVERALL RANK

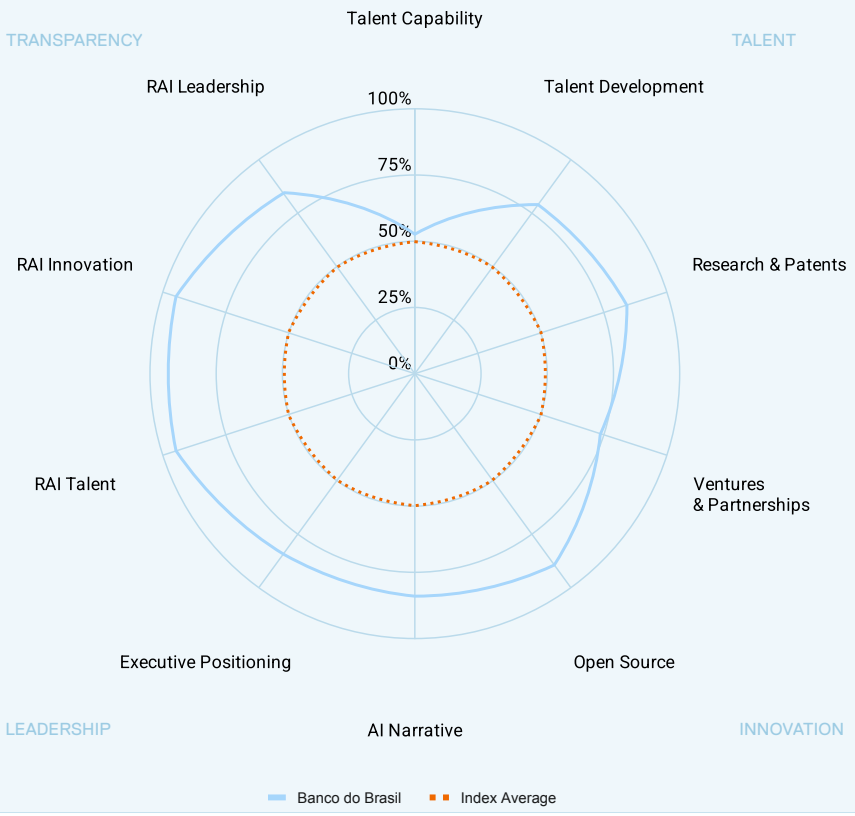
4

REGION

PILLAR RANK

TRANSPARENCY	TALENT
2	9
LEADERSHIP	**INNOVATION**
4	4

Index Performance Profile: Banco do Brasil
Percentile Rank of Index Score, by Subpillar



3.1 TALENT

LATAM PRODUCES GLOBALLY COMPETITIVE AI TALENT, BUT STRUGGLES TO PROTECT IT

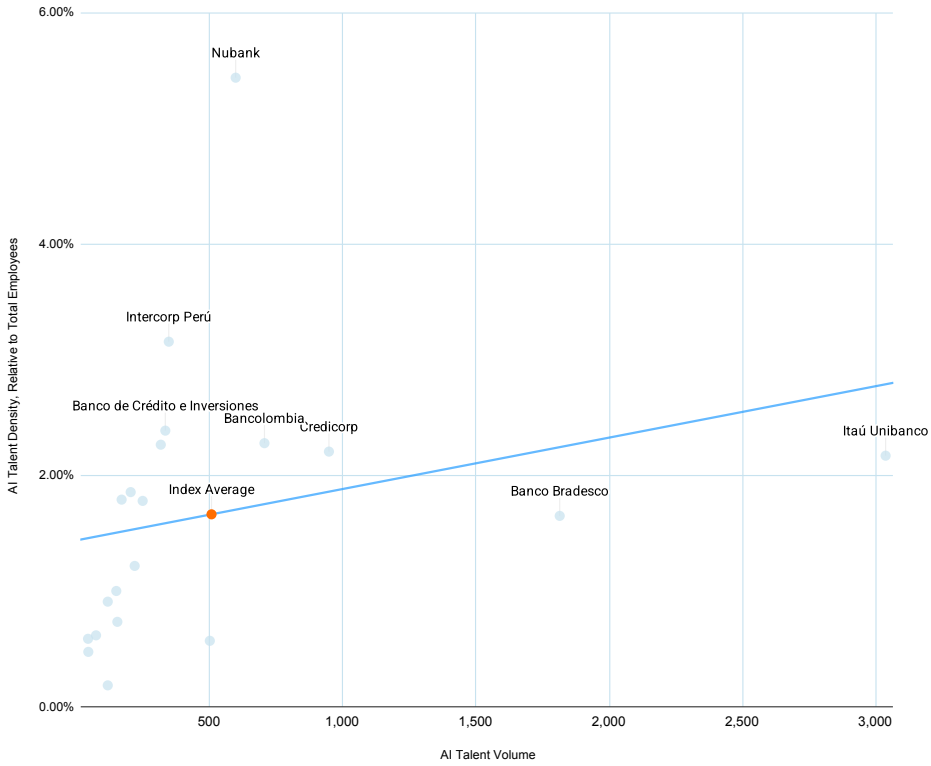
Proximity to strong technical universities and a thriving fintech ecosystem have produced a highly competitive pipeline of engineering and research talent within LATAM, leading the establishment of recognized AI hubs in São Paulo, Mexico City and Santiago.

Itaú Leads in Volume, Nubank Leads in "Density" of AI Talent

As a result, the 20 LATAM banks collectively employ over 10 thousand AI workers across four Capability Areas (AI Development, Data Engineering, AI Software Implementation, and AI Product Management). On average, this represents 1.7% of overall headcount.

While trailing benchmarks set by global banks (where AI roles now account for 2.2% of overall headcount), the LATAM banks mimic their global counterparts in that they diverge into high-volume, lower-density organizations (e.g. Itaú Unibanco) versus lower-volume, high-density organizations (e.g. Nubank).

AI TALENT VOLUME VS. DENSITY, RELATIVE TO TOTAL EMPLOYEES



July 2026, n=20 LATAM Banks

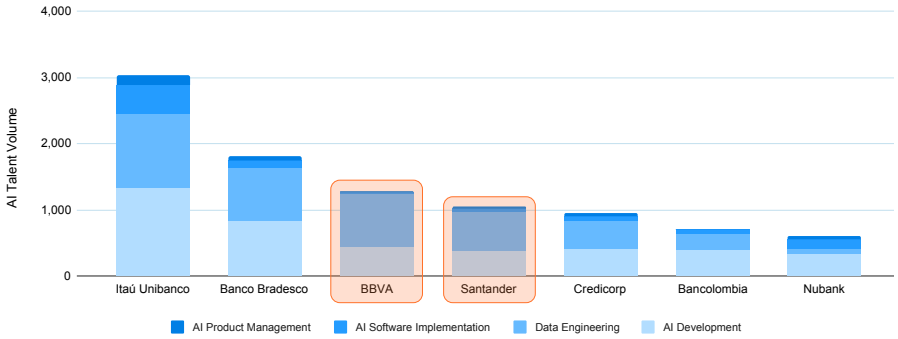
As a result, the implications of rising competition for AI talent are unlikely to be felt evenly across the region. Large institutions such as Itaú Unibanco and Bradesco benefit from substantial absolute AI talent pools, giving them greater resilience to turnover and a deeper bench from which to scale AI initiatives.

By contrast, banks with smaller AI teams often exhibit much higher talent density, with AI specialists accounting for a larger share of the workforce. While this can create agility and focus, as we see at Nubank, it also makes these institutions more exposed to talent attrition, as the departure of a relatively small number of specialists can have a disproportionate impact on AI delivery and capability building.

Regional Talent Landscape Complicated by Multinational Players

But the profile above is limited to *in-region* dynamics. It ignores the fact that there are also several major multinational banks (ranked in the Global Evident AI Index for Banks) that maintain an outsized presence in the region. Specifically, AI workers employed by local subsidiaries of BBVA and Santander would easily rank as the third and fourth largest talent pools in the region when compared head-to-head with regional banks.

COMPARATIVE AI TALENT VOLUME, BY CAPABILITY AREA

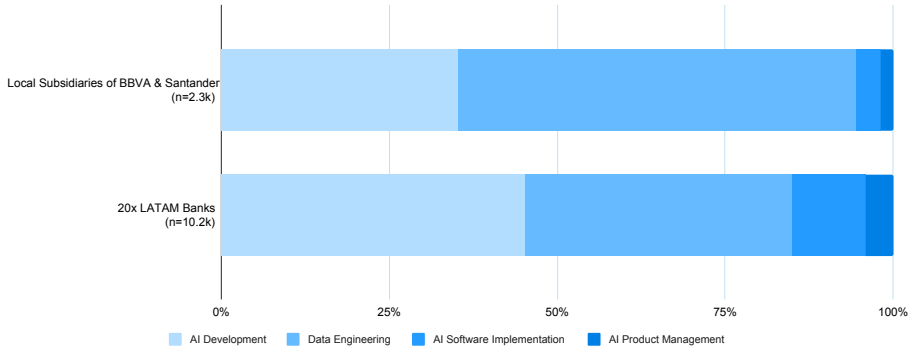


Top-5 Regional Banks vs. Local Subsidiaries of Select Global Peers

This outsized influence is the direct result of both banks maintaining a long-standing presence in the region. In July 2020, Santander launched its Research & Development Center in São Carlos. And more recently, in August 2024, BBVA officially extended the footprint of its global AI Factory by launching a regional hub in Mexico City.

But the regional AI workforce of these banks is not only significant in terms of scale, but also composition. The type of local talent BBVA and Santander are recruiting has a distinct signature, heavily skewing towards Data Engineering roles (by 1.5x).

BREAKDOWN OF AI TALENT VOLUME, BY CAPABILITY AREA



Regional Banks vs. Local Subsidiaries of Select Global Peers

This configuration makes sense. Unlike regional banks, BBVA and Santander increasingly build technology platforms that are reused across multiple geographies. This requires more Data Engineering talent to standardize models, build reusable ingestion pipelines, and support localized data platforms. This is the difference between an engineering hub supporting global efforts – versus a team building an end-to-end system for their home market.

The renewed presence of international banks is double-sided. On the one hand, re-orienting AI talent in the region stands to deepen local AI capabilities. BBVA's ongoing investment in Mexico appears to be an example of this: now totalling more than 700 AI professionals across its talent stack. Meanwhile, the ~300 AI professionals we observe at Santander Brazil (a subsidiary that makes up ~15-20% of the wider group) have reportedly delivered "400 AI initiatives", with AI now making card fraud processing 95% faster and 90% automated in the country.

Conversely, regional banks in need of this same talent face an uphill battle in terms of matching the prestige, compensation, and future opportunities offered by their global peers. Moreover, while there is limited evidence of LATAM banks running highly visible recruitment campaigns for software engineers, data scientists, or STEM graduates – the same cannot be said for the global competition.

In April, Santander announced it would make 400+ job offers across 10 countries through its Young Talent Program – specifically targeting graduates in engineering, data, digital product, design, and business fields.

Increasingly, global firms provide a pathway for top local engineers to participate in international AI programs, raising the opportunity cost for domestic banks seeking to build and retain proprietary AI capabilities.

3.2 INNOVATION

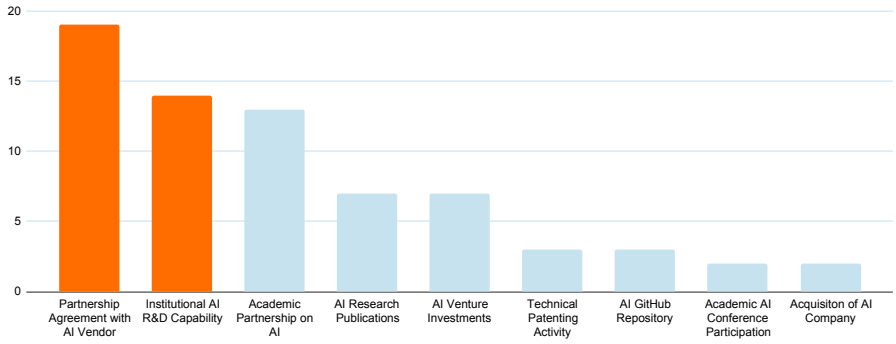
EXPANDING HYPERSCALER INFRASTRUCTURE IMPROVES ACCESS TO FRONTIER AI, PUSHING LATAM BANKS TO FAVOR "BUY" VS. "BUILD"
Against this backdrop of scarce AI talent in Latin America, banks here are faced with a familiar question for technology adoption in the region: *How to do more with less*? At the same time, this has renewed pressure on firms to reorient their Innovation strategies towards "buy" (versus "build"), as they prioritize tangible outcomes from ongoing AI investments.

AI Research Driven by Applied Approaches, Not Academic Publications
While large global players have historically invested in academic research and publication to develop internal build capabilities and attract leading AI researchers, this model is far less common in Latin America.

Evident tracks this activity by looking beyond just traditional academic research outputs to consider a bank's capacity to systematically develop, experiment with and scale AI capabilities. The hallmarks of such "Institutional R&D" efforts are observed through AI leadership roles (including Heads of AI Research or Lead AI Scientist) as well as specialized units such as AI Centers of Excellence, research labs and innovation hubs.

Where innovation strategies do favor in-house development, we observe less of a focus on pure academic research, and more on these applied, business-focused R&D efforts. Such initiatives demonstrate that while banks are investing in internal innovation capacity, they are primarily designed to accelerate adoption and business transformation.

TOTAL BANKS WITH EVIDENCE OF SPECIFIED ACTIVITY AND/OR CAPABILITY



July 2026, n=20 LATAM Banks

Examples of these initiatives include:

→ Meanwhile, **Banco Bci's** innovation activity is coordinated through Bci Labs and a dedicated Generative AI Center of Excellence within the bank's Data & Analytics division, reporting directly to the CEO. This organizational structure reflects a strong emphasis on translating AI experimentation into business outcomes rather than pursuing standalone research agendas – an approach that often requires years of investment to bear fruit.

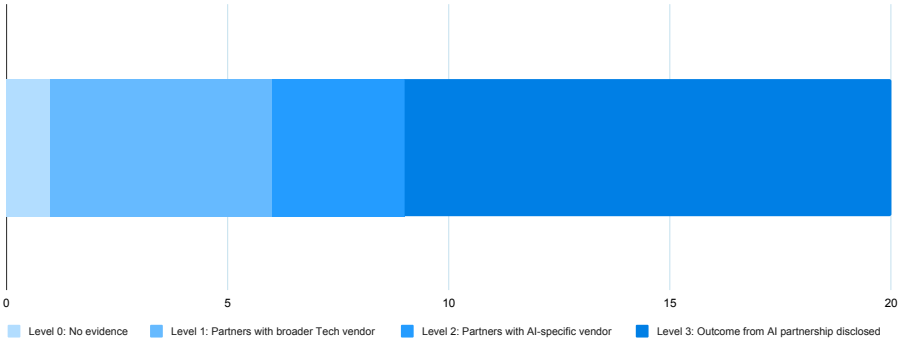
→ **Banorte**, where the Cognitive Competence Center serves as a vehicle for developing the bank's AI strategy, testing concepts and piloting emerging technologies before scaling them into the business.

Only a select number of leaders have pursued more "traditional" research approaches through publication of papers and/or partnerships with academic institutions.

Again Nubank and Itaú stand out as notable exceptions here. A significant research paper in 2025 from a team at Nubank details the ongoing development of its proprietary foundation models for credit underwriting, providing rare evidence of differentiation through frontier model development that originates from within the region's banking sector.

Vendor Partnerships Augment Internal AI Deployment & Deliver Value
Beyond foundational cloud partnerships with AWS, Microsoft and Google, and the integration of these models through compute platforms like Bedrock, Azure, and Gemini Enterprise, institutions are increasingly working with specialist AI vendors to accelerate deployment of high-value use cases.

ASSESSMENT OF EXTERNAL PARTNERSHIPS WITH TECH VENDORS



July 2026, n=20

At the leading edge, Nubank's partnership with OpenAI is the clearest example of a LATAM bank collaborating directly with a frontier AI lab. The bank combines its own proprietary customer data and internally developed models with OpenAI capabilities to support customer service, knowledge retrieval and operational workflows.

Across the wider Index, however, value is being realised through partnerships with more conventional enterprise AI vendors. Rather than pursuing bespoke cutting-edge AI development, many banks are deploying more standard "off-the-shelf" solutions to address targeted operational and commercial challenges.

These partnerships still deliver measurable business outcomes while avoiding significant in-house research and development investment.

BANK	PARTNER	USE CASE	OUTCOME
Bancolombia	Appian	Document Automation and Workflow Orchestration	70% reduction in manual processing
Banco Galicia	Red Hat	Customer onboarding and verification	Reduced verification times from days to minutes while maintaining >90% accuracy
Credicorp	Muttdata	Marketing Optimisation	15% reduction in customer acquisition costs and 74% increase in ROAS with only a 4% increase in marketing investment

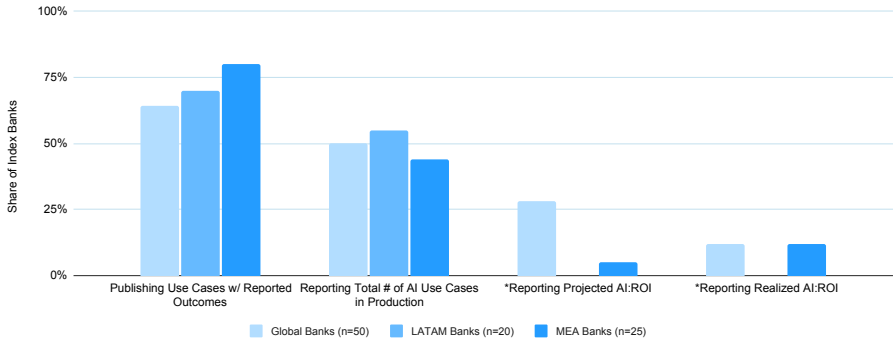
As hyperscalers and leading AI labs expand their footprint in the region, one might argue that local firms further down the ranking - many of which have historically relied on off-the-shelf solutions - stand to benefit from proximity and greater access to state of the art models and managed AI services. However, sustained competitive advantage is still likely to only accrue for those firms that a) have the resources to acquire frontier capabilities, but also b) can combine these technologies with well managed proprietary data, organised AI workflows and internal AI expertise.

3.3 LEADERSHIP

REALIZED ROI HAS NOT LADDERED UP TO THE ENTERPRISE-LEVEL (YET...)
On the surface, LATAM banks prove competitive with both regional and global peers in documenting AI use cases. Over two-thirds (70%) publish use cases with reported outcomes and over half (55%) disclose the total number of use cases in production.

Where LATAM banks fall short is in aggregating reported outcomes from individual use cases up to the enterprise (or group) level. In fact, none of the 20 banks reviewed have put a stake in the ground in terms of either realized or projected ROI across all AI activities. At least, not yet...

SHARE OF BANKS WITH EVIDENCE OF SPECIFIED ACTIVITY AND/OR CAPABILITY, BY INDEX COHORT



*Note: Updated to latest available figures from Evident's AI Use Case Trends in Banking (May 2026).

This stands in sharp contrast to their global peers, where nearly a third (30%) are now doing so – already double the participation rate observed late last year. Among global banks with an active presence in the region, Santander provides one of the most robust examples of ongoing updates on ROI.

BEST PRACTICE: Quarterly AI:ROI Updates From Santander (June 2026)
In June, CDAO Ricardo Martín Manjón provided Santander's latest quarterly update, in which he re-iterated the overall target, provided the latest figures, and re-forecast immediate goals through EOY.

→ 185,000 employees with AI access worldwide.

→ €35 million in AI business value during Q1 2026, on track to exceed €200 by year-end.

→ Over €1 billion target value from AI in 2026-2028

→ 17,000 people using AI in software and 40% of code developed by AI in June

→ Openbank's AI models process 100,000 anti-money laundering alerts per year.

→ More than 280 process automation agents in production

Compared to the best practice profiled above, why are we not seeing similar reporting initiatives among regional banks? For many LATAM banks, the challenge is often less about *generating* AI value and more about *measuring* and *aggregating* that value consistently across the enterprise.

Bradesco Teases Realized ROI via ExCo Interviews
Some LATAM banks are simply earlier in their transition from isolated AI projects to enterprise AI platforms. As such, use cases are often owned by individual business units. This stands in stark contrast to large global banks, which have spent years building centralized AI governance, AI offices, and value-tracking processes that allow them to progressively report enterprise-level productivity and financial outcomes.

There is also a disclosure incentive issue. Many global banks are under intense investor pressure to justify multi-billion-dollar technology budgets, which encourages public ROI reporting. In contrast, leading LATAM banks tend to discuss AI through the lens of digital transformation, customer experience, efficiency, and growth rather than publishing consolidated enterprise AI ROI metrics. Recent examples include:

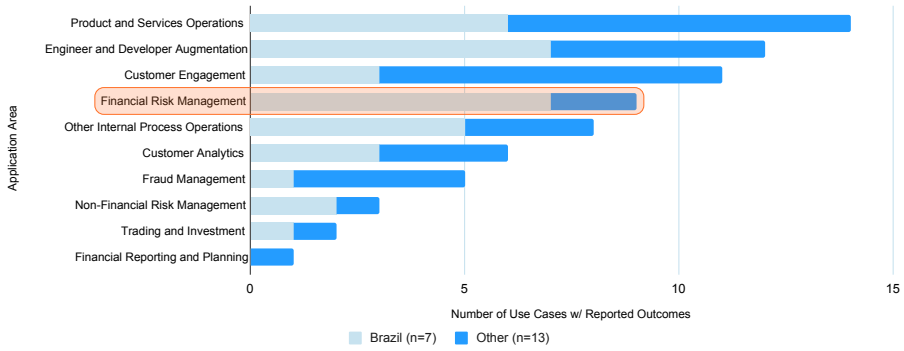
BANK	SOURCE	COMMENTARY
Nubank	David Vélez (CEO) "Building Nubank" Technical Blog	"AI can be the vehicle that will lead us to expand this [customer] love even further, either by enhancing products, services, or by **reducing costs** for the customer."
Itaú Unibanco	Milton Maluhy Filho (CEO) Q4 2025 Earning Calls	"We launched Itaú Emps, a 100% AI-powered platform with **tremendous future potential** as part of our value delivery and business model..."
Banco Bradesco	Management Report: Technology & Innovation 1Q 2026 Financial Statement	"In less than a year, [our proprietary AI] platform **tripled the number of initiatives** and surpassed 660 use cases, covering more than 90 areas and with about 120 solutions. This advance accelerates the practical application of generative AI in products, channels and processes, with governance, security and reuse of services, **reducing the time** between the design and delivery of solutions."

As a result, the value generated from AI may be substantial, but it remains distributed across operational KPIs rather than reported as a single enterprise-wide AI number. But there are clear signs that select banks moving progressively in that direction. For example, in April, André Duarte Oliveira, Bradesco's Executive Officer responsible for CRM and Data Intelligence cited where and how AI is already having a significant impact on the business. Specifically, he shared how the bank's application of AI in credit has already generated over $1B BRL ($193 USD) in additional net income – distinct from other positive externalities that are harder to measure.

Brazilian Banks Over-Investing in Financial Risk Management

When we look at individual use cases at a more granular level, we get a better sense of where leading banks are investing to unlock incremental value. Overall, the 71 use cases with reported outcomes are evenly split between Brazilian banks (49%) and their regional peers (51%). However, established leaders in Brazil over-index in select application areas.

CLASSIFICATION OF USE CASES, BY APPLICATION AREA



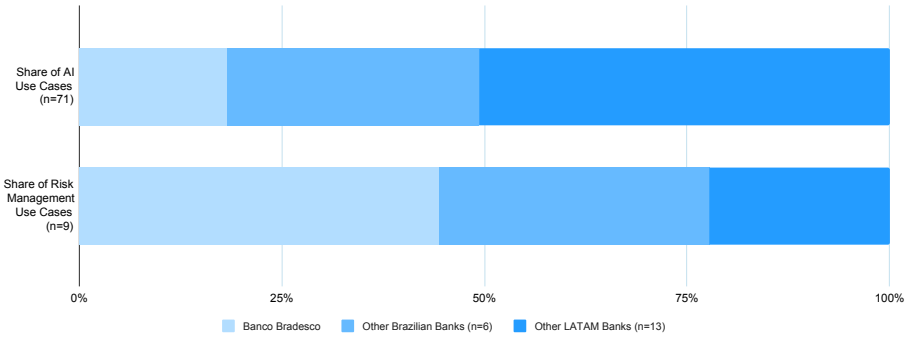
July 2026, n=71 use cases

Evident's latest use case data shows Brazilian banks have been highly proactive in applying AI to Financial Risk Management functions. This application area remains of high strategic importance throughout the region, as it addresses an operating environment characterized by higher inflation, interest-rate volatility, and exchange-rate fluctuations. These factors can rapidly alter borrowers' repayment capacity and asset quality.

To that end, UBS BB recently released a new study examining the stability of assets held by banks in Mexico, Peru, Colombia, Chile, and Brazil. Headline news: Brazil was the only country where assets at risk of default were increasing across both personal and corporate banking.

Despite these warning signs, incumbent banks in Brazil (including Itaú, Bradesco, and Santander) continue to demonstrate manageable rates for non-performing loans (1.9% - 4.2%), especially in comparison to Nubank (5%). Among those incumbents, Bradesco accounts for nearly half of Financial Risk Management applications found across the region.

BANCO BRADESCO AGGRESSIVELY APPLYING AI TO RISK MANAGEMENT FUNCTIONS



July 2026, n=20 LATAM Banks

Bradesco's AI use cases have been steadily growing here over the past two years, evolving the bank's Income Estimate Model that processes incoming transactional data, credit history, and alternative data to predict net income. By more accurately predicting a borrower's repayment capacity (independent of self-reported income), Bradesco effectively limits its short-term exposure, directly protecting its profit line from excessive delinquency charges. To that end, the bank reported in May that it had achieved nine consecutive quarters of recurring improving net income (+16.1% YoY).

3.4 TRANSPARENCY

AI GOVERNANCE POLICY IS LAGGING PACE OF AI IMPLEMENTATION
Compared with the more mature Responsible AI (RAI) frameworks emerging in Europe (EU AI Act) and North America (NIST AI Risk Management Framework), Latin American regulators have largely adopted an exploratory and consultative approach.

The one notable exception here is again Brazil, which became the fifth country (and first in the global south) to sign a Digital Partnership agreement with the EU in June 2026 – strengthening potential cooperation across a host of common interests, including: data governance, artificial intelligence, digital infrastructure, and digital goods/services.

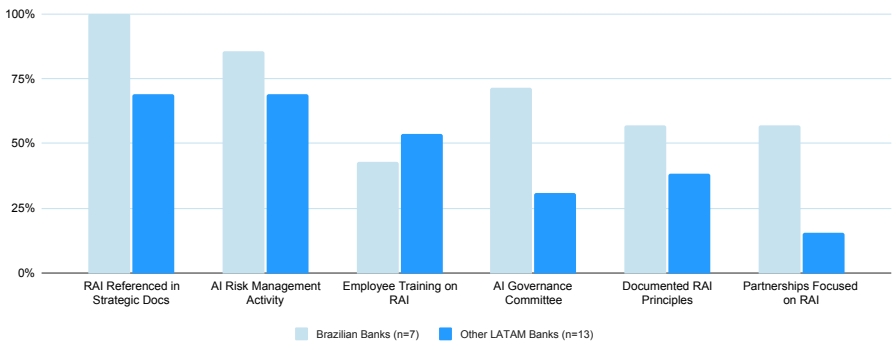
That said, policy recommendations specific to the financial sector demonstrate growing awareness of the risks associated with AI, but thus far, have not produced AI-specific supervisory guidance (or exact timelines for implementation) for banks operating in the region.

JURISDICTION	REGULATOR	SUMMARY
Brazil	Banco Central do Brasil (BCB) Regulatory priorities for 2025/2026	In May 2025, the BCB made AI a formal 2025–2026 supervisory priority, specifically to study the risks and impacts of AI use by financial institutions. This signals movement toward bank-facing expectations on model risk, data governance, cybersecurity, and customer protection.
Peru	Superintendencia de Banca, Seguros y AFP (SBS) Position Statement on AI in Finance	In January 2025, the SBS reviewed a proposed law to promote AI in the financial system and argued that AI should be governed through a broad national AI framework. It highlighted ethics, transparency, risk management, data security, cybersecurity, and consumer protection as the key banking-sector issues.
Colombia	Superintendencia Financiera (SFC) Innovation Framework	The SFC has not issued a standalone AI rule for banks, but its innovation framework lists Open Finance rules, cybersecurity, biometrics, cloud, SARLAFT 4.0, and smart supervision as active supervisory building blocks. These directly shape the data-sharing, consent, security, and model-governance environment in which bank AI systems will operate.

Instead, regulators remain focused on monitoring developments, assessing potential risks, and incorporating AI considerations into broader agendas spanning digital innovation, cybersecurity, data governance, and consumer protection. Notably, current regulatory roadmaps generally stop short of prescribing binding controls, compliance obligations, or implementation timelines.

Brazilian Banks Channel RAI Rhetoric into Impactful Partnerships
Despite this lack of top-down governance directive, the majority of LATAM banks demonstrate a concerted focus on RAI activities. 16 banks (80%) reference RAI commitments in strategic docs, 10 banks (50%) are offering RAI-specific training to employees, and 9 banks have published RAI principles (the majority of which include examples of active implementation). In addition, select banks (e.g. Banco Bradesco) have published Trustworthy AI frameworks aligned with emerging international standards (e.g. OECD).

SHARE OF BANKS WITH EVIDENCE OF SPECIFIED ACTIVITY AND/OR CAPABILITY, BY REGIONAL COHORT



July 2026, n=20 LATAM Banks

As observed in the Leadership pillar, Brazilian banks remain an edge across most of Evident's assessment criteria – especially when it comes to documenting RAI-centric partnerships with strategic partners (e.g., academia, government, or industry) that yield a case study, use case, or outcome.

Prime examples include:

→ **Banco do Brasil:** In 2025, the bank announced a joint partnership with IBM and EY to build and operationalize enterprise-wide AI governance. EY designed a Gen AI Lifecycle framework and Continuous AI Monitoring framework, while IBM implemented governance controls through its Watsonx.governance toolkit.

→ **Branco Bradesco:** Last November, the bank shared recent work with Microsoft and Avanade centered on its "Bridge" multi-agent AI platform. As part of a wider transformation initiative, this case study repeatedly emphasizes secure deployment, AI service governance, compliance controls, API governance, and enterprise oversight.

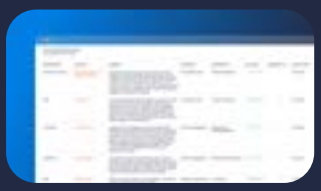
EVIDENT AI INDEX BANKS/LATAM

Work with Evident

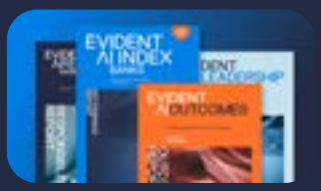
Evident is the leading benchmarking and intelligence platform for AI in financial services. We give enterprise AI leaders the benchmarks, data and research they need to make confident decisions, accelerate adoption and build AI programs that scale.



AI BENCHMARKING
Private and public AI benchmarking to assess your organization's AI capabilities and maturity



DATA TRACKERS
500+ AI Use Cases
1,000+ AI Research Papers
1,000+ AI Patents
900+ Ventures



TRENDS REPORTS
Cutting-edge trend reports on AI adoption, investment and innovation



COMMUNITY
Evident AI Symposium
Virtual roundtables
Member dinners

AI BENCHMARKING

PUBLIC BENCHMARKING
Unpack your organization's standing in the Evident AI Index and identify opportunities to accelerate AI capabilities.

PRIVATE BENCHMARKING
Benchmark your AI use cases, spend and returns against major financial institutions. Determine where your AI deployment stands now, and where to focus investment next.

INTELLIGENCE

DATA TRACKERS
Track AI innovation, investment and adoption across financial services with our comprehensive databases of the latest use cases, research, patents and ventures.

TRENDS REPORTS
Explore the emerging trends shaping AI in financial services with cutting-edge research reports.

NEWS
Stay ahead of the curve with the latest, curated insights on the technologies, policies and innovations shaping AI in financial services.

COMMUNITY

EVIDENT AI SYMPOSIUM
Our annual gathering of senior AI leaders in financial services. We come together each year to get real answers on how to drive AI transformation forward.

ROUNDTABLES
Live and on-demand virtual roundtables. Put your questions to our experts and top AI practitioners shaping the future of finance.

MEMBER DINNERS
Connect and network with peers and AI thought leaders at intimate member-only dinners.

To learn more about how your organization can work with Evident, get in touch with our team

RETURN TO TOP ↑